INTRODUCTION

Smoke Is Not the Fire

Kahu Phil Stephens

Every rancher knows there comes a day when he has to walk the fence.

It doesn't matter if the pasture is one acre or one thousand. Sooner or later, every fence must be inspected. The wire stretches. The staples loosen. The wind blows. The rain falls. Cattle lean against it. Time quietly does what time has always done.

Most people begin by looking at the wire.

If the fence is leaning, they tighten the wire.

If a staple has pulled loose, they drive in another one.

If the paint has faded, they buy another bucket.

They work hard.

They spend money.

They honestly believe they are fixing the problem.

But the old rancher walks a little slower.

He doesn't begin with the wire.

He doesn't even begin with the paint.

His eyes go directly to the post.

Because he knows something that only years of experience can teach.

A fence almost never fails because of the wire.

It fails because something underneath has already begun to rot.

A post can look perfectly healthy from the outside while the inside has already become soft. It may still hold the wire today. It may even survive the next storm.

But the day is coming when someone—or something—will lean against it one last time.

Then everything falls.

The surprising part is that the collapse didn't begin that day.

It began years earlier.

Long before anyone noticed.

Long before anyone cared.

Long before anyone thought there was a problem.

That simple lesson has stayed with me far longer than any ranch chore ever did.

Over the years I began seeing rotten fenceposts everywhere.

Not just in pastures.

In families.

In businesses.

In schools.

In governments.

In churches.

In our health.

Even in our own hearts.

Everywhere I looked, I saw people working incredibly hard to repair what everyone else could see while ignoring what was quietly failing underneath.

The world has become very good at treating symptoms.

It has become much less interested in discovering causes.

If the roof leaks, put out another bucket.

If the weeds grow taller, buy a stronger chemical.

If the pain returns, increase the dosage.

If we're tired, drink another energy drink.

If we're anxious, distract ourselves.

If we're overweight, chase another diet.

If business slows down, spend more on advertising.

If relationships struggle, buy another gift.

We have become experts at polishing the visible while neglecting the invisible.

And because of that, many of us spend years fixing the same problems over and over again.

The names change.

The circumstances change.

The technology changes.

But the pattern remains exactly the same.

We repair the fence.

We ignore the post.

That pattern is what this book is about.

This is not merely a book about health, although health is certainly part of it.

It is not merely a book about finances, although money often follows the same pattern.

It is not merely a book about leadership, families, education, or faith.

It is about learning to recognize a principle that quietly governs nearly every part of life.

Once you see it, you cannot unsee it.

You'll begin noticing it in conversations.

You'll recognize it in headlines.

You'll see it in advertisements promising quick fixes.

You'll hear it in political speeches.

You'll recognize it in your doctor's office.

You'll even catch yourself doing it in your own life.

The Rotten Fencepost Principle is remarkably simple.

Every visible problem is supported by something underneath.

Sometimes the visible problem is the real problem.

Most of the time, it isn't.

The visible problem is simply the symptom telling us where to begin looking.

Imagine seeing smoke rising above the trees.

No one would spend the afternoon trying to sweep the smoke away.

We instinctively know smoke is not the problem.

Smoke is the evidence that something else is burning.

The same is true in life.

Symptoms are not enemies.

Symptoms are messengers.

Pain is a messenger.

Fatigue is a messenger.

Conflict is a messenger.

Debt is a messenger.

Loneliness is a messenger.

Confusion is a messenger.

Ignoring the messenger never removes the cause.

Yet that is exactly what our culture encourages us to do.

We have become uncomfortable with slowing down long enough to ask a simple question:

"What is really causing this?"

That question has changed my life more than almost any other.

Not because it always gives an immediate answer.

But because it points me in the right direction.

Over the years I have learned that most lasting solutions require humility before they require effort.

Humility to admit that what we're seeing may not be the real problem.

Humility to stop blaming everyone else.

Humility to examine ourselves honestly.

Humility to accept that replacing one rotten post is often easier than continually repairing an entire broken fence.

That lesson has served me as a pastor.

It has served me as a rancher.

It has served me in Hawaiian communities.

It has served me while studying Scripture.

It has served me while watching people struggle with their health, their finances, their marriages, and their purpose.

Although every situation is unique, the principle rarely changes.

Healthy roots produce healthy fruit.

Strong foundations support lasting structures.

Good soil grows healthy plants.

Solid fenceposts hold strong fences.

The opposite is equally true.

Rot underneath eventually becomes visible above.

It always does.

Maybe not today.

Maybe not tomorrow.

But eventually.

And when it does, we usually call it a crisis.

The truth is, the crisis often began years before anyone noticed.

This book is an invitation.

Not to become suspicious of everything.

Not to assume every answer is simple.

But to become curious enough to look beneath the surface.

Because once we begin fixing causes instead of chasing symptoms, something remarkable happens.

We stop running in circles.

We stop repeating the same battles.

We stop spending our lives repainting fences that no longer have posts strong enough to hold them.

Instead...

We begin building something that can stand.